all came to see, touch, hug and bless what had begun to resemble a pilgrimage.

The march usually began very early in the morning, a little after dawn, and when it reached the northern parts of the country and also hit winter, with late sunrise and biting cold, it often began when it was still dark. After walking for three to four hours, the marchers would stop for a long break at a camp, which consisted of huge tents with mattresses, camp beds and blankets spread out on the bare ground, and a dining tent where lunch was served. During this break, which lasted four to five hours, Rahul Gandhi also met local people in groups—of activists, of professionals, of people pursuing different occupations—and listened to their suggestions and problems. The march resumed around three or four in the afternoon, and often ended in a public meeting at the night stop, which would be attended by thousands. Occasionally, a huge public rally would be organized by the local political activists, the one in Maharashtra attracting lakhs of participants. In the national capital, Delhi, huge crowds lined the streets and thousands attended the public meeting at the Red Fort. As the Yatra wound its way through the northern states in December and January, and it got colder and colder, Rahul Gandhi continued to walk in his trademark T-shirt without adding another layer, while all those walking with him were buttoned up in warm jackets, topped by mufflers and caps. This soon became the talk of the town, and the village, with all kinds of speculation about the reasons, with Rahul's cryptic answer to queries that he would wear something more when he needed to only adding to it. Some unfriendly commentators even wondered whether he was wearing some warm inners and commented on his T-shirt collar being buttoned up! Others wondered whether he was a yogi. Clearly, the media, which started off by studiously and assiduously ignoring the Yatra, had swallowed the bait! Much later, Rahul Gandhi revealed that he had taken the decision not to wear anything warm till he could bear it after he met these very poor children on the Yatra and on holding their hands realized they were shivering in the early-morning cold because they did not have enough clothes to wear. It may sound a bit over the top, but one does wonder if it has any resemblance to